

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

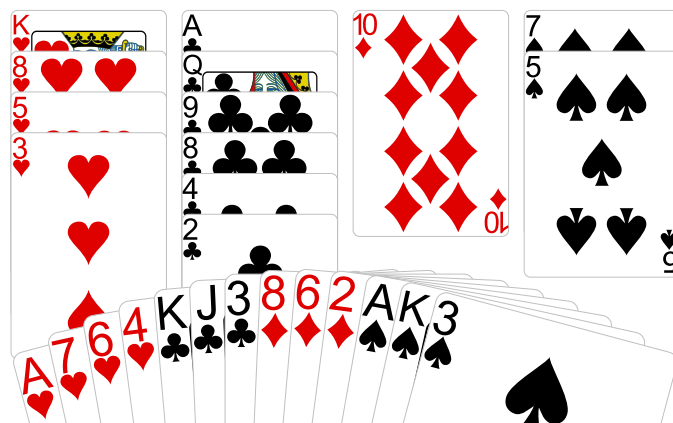
You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Deal 1 Ctr: 6♥ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: 4♥ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 6♥ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥

Declarer: North

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: East

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥

Declarer: West

Board: 5

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 1NT

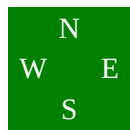
Declarer: North

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ K J 6 2
♥ 3
♦ 9 8 4 2
♣ Q T 6 3

♠ Q T 9 4
♥ A Q 8 6
♦ A K
♣ A J 4



♠ 8
♥ 7 5 2
♦ J T 7 3
♣ K 9 8 5 2

♠ A 7 5 3
♥ K J T 9 4
♦ Q 6 5
♣ 7

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by North

North plays 6♥. East leads the ♠8. To play the ♠A or not to play the ♠A, that is the question.

Loser List: ♠ = 2? : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

At first thought it seems the ♠ lead has saved you a guess in the suit. By playing low in dummy you will force West to put on the King, (if he has it), winning the trick but leaving you with a pretty good position in ♠s.

That's why it's good to have second thoughts at the Bridge table. Think about the meaning of the ♠8 lead. If it is fourth down, then the Rule of 11 tells you that there will be 3 cards higher than the 8 spread among South, West, and North. **BUT YOU CAN SEE 4 HIGHER CARDS.** So your conclusion is that East has **NOT** made a fourth-down lead, but rather has led top-of-nothing, top-of-a-doubleton, or perhaps a singleton.

You don't know which of the above, but you do know that West holds both the ♠ K J. The danger is if the ♠8 is a singleton and you play low from dummy they could get a ♠ trick and a ♠ ruff. So don't play low from dummy. Win the ♠A at trick 1, pull trumps and then play ♠s from dummy toward your ♠ Q 10 9, giving West the ♠K but finessing him out of his known ♠J.

If West led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 2 then it wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If West led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 or ♠ 8 2 then it also wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If West led the singleton ♠8 then you had better play the ♠A or you will be down before you start.

It is unlikely that West would lead the ♠8 from any holding containing one or both of the honors.

First find out about Major suit fits by bidding Stayman. So bid 3♣ and partner says 3♥. What now?

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Feel free to use Blackwood. But if partner shows 3 Aces you only have enough points to bid 6, and if he shows 2 Aces you would still bid 6. So Blackwood will keep you out of slam if he has only 1 Ace. Or, you could just take a chance and bid 6♥.

The contract would be 6♥ played by South.

To rotate the hands and make North the declarer

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

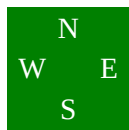
♠ 7 5
 ♥ K 8 5 3
 ♦ T
 ♣ A Q 9 8 4 2

♠ Q J T 4 2

♥ T

♦ A 9 5 4 3

♣ 7 6



♠ A K 3
 ♥ A 7 6 4
 ♦ 8 6 2
 ♣ K J 3

♠ 9 8 6

♥ Q J 9 2

♦ K Q J 7

♣ T 5

West	North	East	South
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2♣

Pass

2♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by East
 the trick and South switches to the ♠9.

Never mind trying to decide how to show the ♣ suit;
 with a 4-card Major your obligation is to use
 Stayman.

You say 2♣ and partner bids 2♥. What now?

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You say 2♣ and partner bids 2♥. What now?

Again, never mind the ♣ suit. You have an 8-card
 Major fit and enough points for game, so you bid
 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by West.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♦K. The ♦K holds

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1/2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2/3

This looks like a walk in the park. Play 2 rounds of trumps, and if they split 3-2 go ahead and force the master trump out. The rest of the tricks would then be yours.

But North shows out on the second trump lead. Ouch!

DO NOT PLAY ANOTHER TRUMP! If you do, then South will pull all the trumps and then North/South will win some ♦s. Many, many ♦s.

Instead just start playing good ♣s. South can ruff in whenever he wants but you will maintain trump control. South can get both master trumps but nothing else.

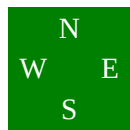
It is usually correct to leave a master trump undrawn, just let the defender ruff in whenever he wants.

Here that principle applied even though there were **TWO** master trumps out.

Board 3
 South Deals
 None Vul

♠ T 9 7 4
 ♥ J 9 6
 ♦ T 8 5
 ♣ A Q J

♠ K Q 3
 ♥ A 7 3
 ♦ Q J 3
 ♣ T 9 6 3



♠ 8 5 2
 ♥ Q T 5 2
 ♦ 9 7 4 2
 ♣ K 8

♠ A J 6
 ♥ K 8 4
 ♦ A K 6
 ♣ 7 5 4 2

West	North	East	South
			1NT

Pass	3NT
All Pass	

3NT by South

A defender will definitely win this, and probably continue ♠s (but if they switch you would play the same way). You win the ♠ and play another ♣.

West wins and plays another ♠; you win and play another ♣. Deja vu.

West wins again, cashed his established ♠, and exits with a red card. You win and claim the rest of the tricks, including your now-established ♣.

You were able to establish a ♣ because that suit split 3-2.

And you did it without going down because the ♠s split 4-3.

This may seem lucky to you, but don't knock it, it was your **ONLY** chance.

With 12 points and no 4-card Major suit this one is easy. You bid 3NT of course.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠ T and East follows with the ♠ 2.

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 8

There is just no way your ninth winner can come from ♠s, ♥s, or ♦s. So by process of elimination you have to get a ♣ trick.

Win the first trick, probably in your hand, and play a ♣.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A Q 5
♥ Q T 9 3
♦ A J T 7
♣ A 8

♠ K 8 3

♥ 5

♦ Q 9 6 4 2

♣ T 9 7 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 6 2

♥ A K J 6 4 2

♦ K

♣ J 6 4

♠ T 9 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ 8 5 3

♣ K Q 5 2

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	2♦	Pass
3♥	Pass	4NT	Pass
5♠	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by West
slim possibility that partner has only one Ace!

Your partnership may play that a jump to 3♥ shows a 6-card suit with slam interest, in other words, this very hand. If you do, then bid it. If you don't, use a transfer first. Let's say you bid 2♦. Partner jumps to 3♥. Now

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least two Aces for his strong bidding. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and this is certainly not the type of hand where asking for Aces is always helpful - what if partner shows two Aces, aren't you going to bid the slam anyway? The advantage to Blackwood here is that there is just a

You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♠. Next?

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The contract would be 6♥ played by East.

West plays 6♥. North leads the ♣T. You play the ♣J, just in case North made a mistake, but South puts on the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

The ♠ loser is deceptive. You could discard a ♠ from dummy on your ♦A, but would still have a ♠ loser if the finesse doesn't work. Still, this would be one possible plan. Can you improve on that?

Maybe you can. Look harder at the ♦s. Win the ♣A, then play to dummy's ♦K. Pull trumps (2 rounds) ending in your hand. Play your ♦A, but discard a ♣ from dummy, (the key play). Now play your ♦J, and if North plays low, discard dummy's other ♣.

You have gotten rid of the ♣ losers, but if South can win the ♦Q on this trick you will discard a ♠ on the ♦10, but will still have to try the ♠ finesse.

But, if the ♦J holds then it won't matter if the ♠ finesse works or not, you will make the slam.

Suppose when you play your ♦J North puts on the ♦Q.

No problem. You ruff in dummy, come back to your hand with a trump and **THEN** discard dummy's last ♣

Board 5

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 9 5
 ♥ K Q 8 6 3
 ♦ K 6 2
 ♣ A 3

♠ A J 2
 ♥ A T 5
 ♦ A J 7
 ♣ J 9 7 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ T 8 7 4
 ♥ J 9
 ♦ 8 5 4 3
 ♣ K Q T

♠ K 6 3
 ♥ 7 4 2
 ♦ Q T 9
 ♣ 8 5 4 2

West	North	East	South
1♥	1NT		
All Pass			
1NT by North			

With no reason to think you could improve the contract you just pass.

The contract would be 1NT played by South.

North plays 1NT. East leads the ♥J and West plays the ♥8. Do you hold up? If so, how many times?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

It probably makes no difference whether you hold up or not since West surely has most of the high cards. However, holding up once is a good idea because East may have a singleton ♥ and have to switch to something which helps you. East holds the first trick and plays another ♥, which you win.

You must find 4 winners. The bad news is that you must finesse both the ♦K and the ♠Q. The good news is that with West opening the bidding there is a good chance he has both of them. So, how will you manage those two finesses?

There is only one way to do it. Enter dummy with the only entry, the ♠K. Take the ♦ finesse first - play the ♦Q and unblock your ♦J when West plays low. (you could play the ♦10/♦7 combination first).

Finesse the ♦ again. If West ducks a second time you must now take the ♠ finesse while you are still in dummy. If West covers the second ♦ you win with your ♦A, return to dummy with the ♦9, and then finesse the ♠.

Having used dummy's lone entry to get there in the first place you have to make sure you take the finesse that permits you to either remain in dummy, or to return if West plays his King.

And you have to be careful to unblock so you don't inadvertently lose your place in dummy too soon.